





TRUE FRIENDS Ajit Singh and Swami Vivekananda; Motilal Nehru spent a good part of his childhood in Khetri

still Bibidishananda at that stage—it was during a second visit to Khetri, en route to the Parliament of the World's Religions at Chicago, that he took on the name he's famous by. On Ajit Singh's suggestion. The raja, who sponsored Vivekananda's Chicago trip and sent monthly support to his family, was no ordinary disciple-patron. The two, born just a year apart, struck up a bond profound enough for Vivekananda to write in 1898: "I consider you as my only friend in this life." The swami had three stints in Khetri. He spent his days studying Patanjali's *Mahabhashya*—and quotidian Rajasthani life. That trademark turban came from there. The king also died a year before the Vedantin, falling from a tower—in Vivekananda's words, while "restoring some old architectural monument at Agra, at his own expense". Ironically, his own Khetri now lies fallen into ruination.

Not before decades touched by the usual royal distinctions. Three generations down, Sardar Singh's life followed the classic arc of the literate elite—Cambridge, Middle Temple, Constituent Assembly, Rajya Sabha, ambassadorship at Laos. A childless divorcee who usually resided at the Khetri House in Delhi, he had a will executed in the city's Tis Hazari court in 1985, two years before he died. All his moveable and immoveable properties—everything in Khetri, his Delhi residence, and another Khetri House in Jaipur's Chandpole—went into a new entity, the Khetri Trust. Its rolling cast of trustees over the years featured the Delhi cognoscenti—Romesh Thapar, Romila Thapar, Tejbir Singh, Vikram Lal et al—and it fell upon them to engage in legal battle.

For, the Rajasthan government disputed the will's bona fides. So did the swarm of self-proclaimed 'cognates and agnates'—contemporary and next-generation kin—who had materialised out of the blue. Also, Delhi law mandated that wills registered in the city go through the tortuous process of being granted probate—that is, validated by court. Thus started an epic legal tangle that is now in its fourth decade—as sprawling and messy as the cobwebs at a Khetri palace. Cross-woven on that is the sorry tale of Khetri House at Jaipur. Once a three-star hotel (and part-residence), it has seen hell: shutters downed, encroachment, a devastating fire, forged sale of portions of it, elaborate thievery. One heist possibly lasted days—12-inch-thick walls of two iron safes, in two iron rooms, were sawn through with a gas-cutter. "All this while being in state possession!" rues Ajit Singh Shekhawat, ex-DGP, Rajasthan, and a trustee. Managing trustee Prithvi Raj Singh shows numerous letters to the government to allow inspection that went abegging.

ONE HEIST MUST HAVE LASTED DAYS—12-INCH WALLS OF IRON SAFES, IN IRON ROOMS, WERE SAWN THROUGH

But things are coming around. On August 17, goaded by a local court, Jaipur Police lodged an FIR against seven people for the alleged illegal sale and encroachment. Two days earlier, Gaj Singh, erstwhile maharaja of Jodhpur and chair of the trust, called on chief minister Bhajan Lal Sharma. They hope the change in government may presage a change of heart, but aren't taking it for granted: on August 22, the trust sent a notice of contempt to the chief secretary. The ball has been set rolling for a new life for Khetri. The state, chastised in court, has sanctioned Rs 5 crore as a first tranche; restoration has started. "We are committed to protecting our heritage," says deputy CM Diya Kumari—who handles tourism, archaeology and culture. Another positive is that Gaj Singh Alsisar, one of the credible cognates, has withdrawn his claim in favour of the trust. He's building a 103-room hotel on the foothills of the 60-acre Bhopalgarh Fort. The government is promoting a leopard conservatory nearby. A full Khetri package, complete with a Vivekananda circuit, is on the cards.

"Thank God, something good has happened finally," historian Romila Thapar had said last year, when a trustee broke the news of the court decision to her. Back in 2008, over a cup of tea in Delhi, a cognate had made an offer of a three-way split of assets. "Romila, almost with tears in her eyes, said she has to meet Raja Sardar Singh in the afterlife and can't do anything to let him down," says a participant. She quit the trust soon, worn down by years of litigation. All sides coming together constructively may offer the best climax for this particular tale—even if you leave it feeling philosophical. ■